

# An Introduction To SERVERLESS COMPUTING



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In 1990s, Neal Ford (now at ThoughtWorks) worked for a small company focused on a technology called Clipper. By writing an object-oriented framework based on Clipper, they built DOS applications using dBase. With their expertise in Clipper, they had a thriving training and consulting business. Then, all of a sudden the Clipper-based business disappeared with the sudden rise of Windows. With that, Ford and his team went scrambling to learn and adopt new technologies. “Ignore the march of technology at your peril” is the lesson that one can learn from this experience.

Many of us live inside technology bubbles: It is easy to get cozy and lose track of what is happening around us. All of a sudden, when the bubble bursts, we are left scrambling to find some new job or business. Hence it is important to stay relevant. In the 1990s that meant catching up with things like graphical user interfaces (GUIs), client/server technologies, and later the worldwide web. Today, relevance is all about being

agile and leveraging cloud, machine learning, artificial intelligence, etc.

With this background, we delve into serverless computing, which is an emerging topic. In this article, we provide an introduction to serverless computing, serverless approach for your applications, key serverless technologies, and a brief discussion on limitations of the serverless approach.

## Why serverless?

Most of us remember using server machines of one form or another. We remember logging remotely to server machines and working on them for hours. We had cute names for servers—like Bailey, Daisy, Charlie, Ginger and Teddy—and took care of them fondly. However, there were many problems in using physical servers like these:

1. Companies had to do capacity planning and predict the future resource requirements
2. Purchasing servers meant big capital expenses (CAPEX) for companies